

Passages - Nausea

I'm going to bed. I'm cured, and I'm going to give up writing down my impressions, like a little girl, in a nice new notebook.

I think it's I who has changed: that's the simplest solution, also the most unpleasant. But I have to admit that I am subject to these sudden transformations. The thing is that I very rarely think; consequently a host of little metamorphoses accumulate in me without my noticing it, and then, one fine day, a positive revolution takes place.

I turn my back on her. After all, she is lucky. I for my part have been much too calm these last three years. I can receive nothing more from these tragic solitudes, except a little empty purity. I walk away.

Something begins in order to end: an adventure doesn't let itself be extended; it achieves significance only through its death.

Towards this death, which may also be my own, I am drawn irrev-ocably. Each moment appears only to bring on the moments after.

To each moment I cling with all my heart: I know that it is unique, irreplaceable - and yet I would not lift a finger to prevent it from being annihilated.

I had to begin living again, that the impression of having an adventure had just vanished.

When you are living, nothing happens. The settings change, people come in and go out, that's all. There are never any beginnings. Days are tacked on to days without rhyme or reason, it is an endless,

monotonous addition.

Is it even possible to think of somebody in the past? As long as we were in love with each other we didn't allow the tiniest of our moments, the smallest of our sorrows to be detached from us and left behind. Sounds, smells, degrees of light, even the thoughts we had not told each other - we took all this with us and it all remained alive: we never stopped enjoying it and suffering from it in the present. Not a single memory; an implacable, torrid love, without a shadow, without a withdrawal, without an evasion. Three years present at one and the same time. That is why we separated: we no longer had enough strength to bear the burden. And then, when Anny left me, all at once, all together, the three years collapsed into the past. I didn't even suffer, I felt empty. Then time started flowing again and the emptiness grew larger.

'How much simpler and how much more difficult it is to do one's duty!'

He had never gone any further in examining himself: he was a leader.

The destiny of men of his size is always worked out a few inches above their heads.

I exist. It is I. The body lives all by itself, once it has started. But when it comes to thought, it is I who continue it, I who unwind it. I exist. I think I exist. Oh, how long and serpentine this feeling of existing is - and I unwind it, slowly ... If only I could prevent myself from thinking! I try, I succeed: it seems as if my head is filling with smoke . .. And now it starts again: "Smoke...

Mustn't think. I don't want to think ... I think that I don't want to think. I mustn't

think that I don't want to think. Because it is still a thought.' Will there never be an end to it?

My thought is me: that is why I can't stop. I exist by what I think. and I can't prevent myself from thinking At this very moment - this is terrible - if I exist, it is because I hate existing It is I, it is I who pull myself from the nothingness to which I aspire:

I haven't any troubles, I have some money like a gentleman of leisure, no boss, no wife, no children; I exist, that's all. And that particular trouble is so vague, so meta-physical, that I am ashamed of it.

Soon the two of them will form just a single life, a slow, tepid life which will have no significance left at all- but they won't notice that.

I stop listening to them: they annoy me. They are going to sleep together. They know it. Each of them knows that the other knows it. But as they are young, chaste, and decent, as each wants to keep his self-respect and that of the other, and as love is a great poetic thing which mustn't be shocked, they go several times a week to dances and restaurants, to present the spectacle of their ritualistic, mechanical dances..

After all, you have to kill time. They are young and well built, they have another thirty years in front of them. So they don't hurry, they take their time, and they are quite right. Once they have been to bed together, they will have to find something else to conceal the enormous absurdity of their existence. All the same he is it absolutely necessary to lie to each other? I look round the room. What a farce! All these people sitting there looking serious, eating. No, they aren't eating: they are

reviving their strength in order to complete their respective tasks.

I say nothing, I give a forced smile. The waitress puts a plate in front of me with a piece of chalky Camembert on it. I glance round the room and a feeling of violent disgust comes over me. What am I doing here? Why did I get mixed up in a discussion about human-ism? What are these people here? Why are they eating? It's true that they don't know that they exist. I want to leave, to go somewhere where I should be really in my place, where I would fit in. but my place is nowhere; I am unwanted.

I should so like to let myself go, to forget, to sleep. But I can't, I'm suffocating: existence is penetrating me all over, through the eyes, through the nose, through the mouth. ...

And suddenly, all at once, the veil is torn away, I have under-stood, I have seen.

Everything is gratuitous, that park, this town, and myself. When you realize that, it turns your stomach over and everything starts floating about, as it did the other evening at the Rendez-vous des Cheminots; that is the Nausea; that is what the Bastards - those who live on the Coteau Vert and the others - try to hide from themselves with their idea of rights. But what a poor lie: nobody has any rights; they are entirely gratuitous, like other men, they cannot succeed in not feeling superfluous. And in them-selves, secretly, they are superfluous, that is to say amorphous and vague, sad.

At every moment they seemed on the verge of dropping everything and obliterating themselves. Tired and old,

they went on existing, unwillingly and ungraciously, simply because they were too weak to die, because death could come to them only from the outside: melodies alone can proudly carry their own death within them like an internal necessity; only they don't exist. Every existent is born without reason, prolongs itself out of weakness and dies by chance.

She has taken possession of me again, I have plunged back into her strange world, beyond absurdity, affectation, subtlety. I have even rediscovered that little fever which always took hold of me when I was with her, and that bitter taste at the back of my mouth.

Alone and free. But this freedom is rather like death. Today my life comes to an end. 'Tomorrow I shall have left the town which stretches out at my feet, where I have lived so long. It will no longer be anything but a name, stolid, bourgeois, very French, a name in my memory which is not as rich as the names of Florence or Baghdad. A time will come when I shall wonder: 'Whatever did I find to do all day long when I was at Bouville?' And of this sunshine, of this afternoon, nothing will remain, not even a memory.

Above my head, and this moment now, from which I cannot emerge, which shuts me in and hems me in on every side, this moment of which I am made will be nothing more than a confused dream